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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

Build a Crystal Ball: Create Your Own AI Market Intelligence Engine

Date & time: Oct. 15, 11:40 AM-12:25 PM
Track: Build



Grace Clarke

Founder, AI for Normal People

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Session Description

What if your market intelligence didn't just tell you what happened, but what to do next?

In this hands-on Build Session, Grace Clarke will guide you step by step through creating your own AI-powered market intelligence engine. Using a shared sample brand and data set, you'll build an interactive tool that connects customer voice, product reviews, competitive activity, market signals, and business performance to surface the insights that matter and recommend what to do next. By the end of the session, you'll leave with a finished Crystal Ball you built yourself, plus the framework to customize it with your own brand, competitors, reviews, and market data.

Clarke will also show you how to take the concept further by connecting it to live web and business data so it can continuously surface fresh insights and recommendations.

Bring your laptop and be ready to build. Clarke will demonstrate in Claude, which is recommended for the most consistent experience. The core build uses sample data provided in the session and does not require connectors, Claude Code, or Cowork. Access to web search and connected data sources will allow you to extend the tool and maximize its capabilities.

Key Quote

> *"I don't ever want to see a data report or a dashboard without a what should we do next and what do we need to do it."* **- Grace Clarke**

Session Summary

Grace Clarke, founder of AI for Normal People, a hands-on AI curriculum and company training program for non-technical workers, led this Build session on creating an AI-powered market intelligence report. Drawing on her background in marketing and as a fractional CMO, largely in CPG, she explained that she has little interest in data outside the context of what it means for a business, so every report she builds pairs insights with what to do next and the resources needed to do it.

Clarke shared the philosophies behind her approach: connectors, context, and collaboration are the key ingredients, and time saved is only the floor for measuring AI's value, with the real goal being measurable business impact. She argued that prompting is giving way to intent, encouraging attendees to kick off a conversation and get out of the way, and said AI should be treated as a capable colleague rather than an eager intern.

She framed the problem as one she and her clients face constantly: leaders want regular insights but rarely read long reports, data lives in many places, and reports alone do not equal impact. Her solution is to brief AI once with a template that combines insights and action, then deliver the result visually. The original Crystal Ball was built for a beauty brand with exclusivity at Sephora whose leadership wanted something they could scan on their phones as a website.

Attendees worked from a data packet of five Markdown files: a brief, a business overview, company data including SKU sales and thousands of reviews and social posts from Reddit and TikTok transcripts, market and competitor data, and artifact instructions. After uploading the first four and asking for a report, Clarke encouraged several rounds of refinement tied to a specific business goal, then using the artifact file to design the output as plain text, a strategy deck, or an interactive Crystal Ball, and finally publishing it to a URL.

Clarke closed by explaining how to make the tool real with live data: start a new chat with the Markdown files and ask the AI to recreate the process using the company's own information. She described pulling public retailer reviews through platforms like Bazaarvoice and Trustpilot, using Apify for Reddit and other social listening, and using Gemini to analyze video transcripts, along with scheduled tasks such as a weekly website sweep that she runs on a cheaper model once the process is designed.

Key Takeaways

- **Pair every insight with an action:** Clarke builds reports around what to do next and what resources are needed, because she believes reports alone do not equal impact.
- **Lead with intent, not long prompts:** She treats AI as a capable colleague, kicking off a conversation with intent, notes, or a screenshot and then getting out of the way.
- **Refine against a business goal:** Before designing the visual, she goes through several revisions that tie the report to what the business needs to understand and why.
- **Ask for questions first:** Telling AI to ask clarifying questions before it starts reduces the back and forth caused by overly proactive models.
- **Deliver something leaders will read:** Visual artifacts and private URLs, rather than long documents, make insights easier for leadership to scan, including on a phone.
- **Automate market listening:** Public review platforms, Apify for Reddit, and Gemini for video transcripts can feed scheduled tasks that keep the report current.